24x7 political leaders who had their ears to the ground and took the long view.

To illustrate this point, he narrated the story of two by-poll elections that the BJP lost in January 2017. 'Yediyurappa took those two by-polls damn seriously. He stayed there for twenty days, planned every aspect of the campaign and it looked like his life is depending on these by-poll results.' Eventually, the BJP lost both contests, though it increased its vote share. This strategist said that he asked Yediyurappa why he had staked so much on these elections, knowing it was a losing battle anyway and that it would adversely affect his standing. He says Yediyurappa's response was to point out that these two elections were in two different districts where the BJP cadre had not been galvanised and were not active. Yediyurappa told him that 'in those twenty days, half a dozen district guys became active and they all started to do some work. Now they are taking the party work seriously which will help me in 2018 elections. Our focus made Siddaramaiah think that Congress might ending up losing there, so three-fourth of his cabinet and twenty ministers were given the responsibility to win these two seats: ten ministers each. BJP lost these by-polls but it was a moral victory and it helped us in the assembly polls that followed in 2018 in these two districts. That's how you build a cadre.'[111]

Karnataka as the BJP's Springboard for the South

In January 2020, the Karnataka government sought to reopen an alleged rape case of a girl who lived in Kasaragod in neighbouring Kerala. The allegation was that she had been raped by three boys but the Kerala police had not registered a case. Unusually for an incident that had occurred in another state, the BJP's Udupi-Chikkamagaluru MP Shobha Karandlaje took up the case and accompanied the victim for a meeting with Chief Minister Yediyurappa, who in turn asked the Bengaluru police chief to look into the matter. The BJP MP then raised the 'love jihad' angle, alleging that the victim was under pressure from the alleged perpetrators to convert to Islam.[112]